Do svidaniya Brezhnev

On 10 November 1982, Leonid Brezhnev died. Two days later, Yuri Andropov – a grey skinned man who rarely smiled – inherited the mantle of power, along with a dire economy. In many ways, Andropov differed from his predecessor in that he was not a convinced communist in the revolutionary sense. Earlier in his career, he had served as ambassador to Hungary, where he was involved in the suppression of the 1956 uprising. By 1967, he was considered so valuable that Brezhnev named him Chairman of the KGB. Described by Markus Wolf as a closet liberal and even a fan of jazz, Andropov enjoyed an amicable relationship with the SED leadership. He encouraged East Berlin's quest to develop new technology, which Honecker recounted included supporting the GDR's production of new photographic technology. In later years, the First Secretary was keen to point out that a young Soviet politburo member, Mikhail Gorbachev, was also impressed by the GDR's scientific and technical development. 'Our republic was given high marks in all areas,' he recounted, 'including for the new multi-spectral camera and other automatic construction systems, extension of the textile industry, of the glass and plastics industries, of chemistry, shipbuilding and so on.'1

Behind the Kremlin walls, rumblings of discontent at Honecker's hubris and confidence became more vocal. In fact, Honecker was cocky enough to grumble to Andropov about the antics of Pyotr Abrasimov, the Soviet ambassador in East Berlin, who he complained, 'it was impossible to conduct political dialogue with' given his authoritarian manner and propensity to meet Western ambassadors without reference to the GDR government. Such antics finally led to Abrasimov's recall.

Meanwhile, on the international scene, Honecker kept up his foreign travels with state visits to Syria, Kuwait and Cyprus, where he was presented with the 'Order of Makarios' in recognition of his efforts for 'détente and peace and for his consistent support for the people of Cyprus'.